

Notes

- Beef craving satisfied on Sunday (cheesesteaks) and Thursday (pappardelle mushrooms with richness).
- Valentine's heart-shaped mini pizzas for Thursday work potluck — Gen Alpha approved.
- Thursday potluck is lunch; mushroom pappardelle for dinner balances the day.
- Kale and bronzino+kale give two hearty kale nights as requested.
- Saturday is travel day — enchilada components travel well, assemble on arrival.
- This week tells a story in temperatures — from 17°F Sunday to the week's warmth on Tuesday (48°F) and back down again. The dinners follow suit: hearty bookends with lighter, brighter cooking in the middle.
- Two kale nights (Wednesday and Friday) might sound repetitive on paper, but they're completely different experiences — a punchy Caesar versus a Mediterranean fish supper. The green thread ties the week together.

Nutrition at a Glance

This week's dinners are hearty and satisfying — exactly what a cold February demands. Protein variety is outstanding (beef, eggs, dairy, chickpeas, fish, chicken across seven nights), and the two kale-forward dinners provide serious nutrient density midweek. The gaps are what you'd expect from comfort cooking: no whole grains at dinner, limited fruit, and some rich nights. The fix is easy — whole grain lunches, fruit-heavy snacks, and a vitamin D supplement while February keeps the sun at bay. Overall grade: B+, and the lunches and snacks below bring it to an A.

Weekly Planner

FEBRUARY 8 – 14, 2026

Valentine's week in the kitchen: from Philly cheesesteaks on a bone-cold Sunday to Sade spinning over Christmas enchiladas on the 14th — seven nights of comfort, curiosity, and love in action.

Nudges & Reflection

The Sous Chef Moment

Thursday's dinner involves making fresh pasta from scratch — eggs, flour, and rolling. This is the perfect invitation.

Let Elsie handle the pasta dough. Crack the eggs, measure the flour, knead until smooth. Don't correct her technique unless she asks. Let the mess happen.

- 1. Set up her station: apron, flour, eggs, a clean surface
- 2. Show her once how to make the well and crack the eggs in
- 3. Step back. Let her knead. Let her feel the dough change texture.
- 4. When it's smooth, tell her: 'You made that. From scratch. That's real.'

The Valentine Card Factory

Valentine's Day is Saturday but the potluck is Thursday. The week is naturally Valentine-themed — lean into it with a creative project early in the week.

Monday or Tuesday evening, set out supplies and make Valentine cards together — not store-bought, handmade. For friends, for teachers, for each other.

- 1. Gather: construction paper, markers, stickers, scissors, glue
- 2. Each person makes at least 3 cards — including one for each family member
- 3. No templates or Pinterest perfection — messy is better
- 4. Read them aloud to each other before sealing

The Friday Solo Mission

Laura is at book club. Dan is solo with Elsie after YAT pickup at 6 PM. This is a connection goldmine. After dinner, let Elsie choose the entire evening agenda. Movie, game, craft, or just talking. The only rule: no phones for either of you. Call it 'Elsie's Night.'

- 1. On the drive home from YAT, ask: 'Tonight is yours. What do you want to do?'
- 2. Whatever she picks, commit fully. Don't suggest alternatives.
- 3. If she picks a movie, watch it next to her, not across the room.
- 4. Before bed: 'I really liked hanging out with just you tonight.'

📖 Each Kindness by Jacqueline Woodson

A beautiful picture book (yes, even for 8-year-olds) about a girl who misses the chance to be kind to a new student — and the regret that follows. It's short, powerful, and unforgettable. Perfect for Valentine's week because it reframes love as everyday kindness, not grand gestures.

Ties directly to the 'Love in Action' theme. Read it together any night this week — it takes 10 minutes and will generate a conversation that lasts much longer.

This week, pay attention to how Elsie shows love — not how she says it. Does she save you the best piece? Does she draw you a picture unprompted? Does she sit closer to you on the couch? Those small, wordless gestures are her love language developing in real time. Notice them. Name them. 'I saw you saved me the corner piece — that made me feel really loved.' She needs to know her love lands.

You don't need to be a perfect parent — just a present one.

Week at a Glance

DAY	WEATHER	EVENTS	DINNER	ALBUM
Sun 02/08	 Sunny, 17°F / 8°F	—	Philly Cheesesteaks	Franc Moody – Dream in Colour
Mon 02/09	 Sunny, 32°F / 8°F	Conduit Demonstration and Planning 4:00-5:00 PM (Reston Conf Room 5.1B)	Shakshuka with Feta	Makaya McCraven – In These Times
Tue 02/10	 Overcast, 48°F / 26°F	Alex 1:1 3:35-4:00 PM; COBRA Core & Deployments 4:05-4:30 PM; Swim lessons (evening)	Babo Pasta with Alfredo Sauce	Say She She – Prism
Wed 02/11	 Overcast, 45°F / 30°F	—	Kale Caesar Salad with Crispy Chickpeas	Hiroshi Yoshimura – Music for Nine Post Cards
Thu 02/12	 Overcast, 37°F / 27°F	Valentine's Day potluck lunch (bring heart-shaped mini pizzas)	Mushroom Pappardelle with Fresh Egg Pasta	Mulatu Astatke – Mulatu of Ethiopia
Fri 02/13	 Overcast, 36°F / 24°F	Laura book club (evening); Elsie YAT 4:30-6:00 PM	Baked Bronzino with Roasted Kale	Laufey – Bewitched
Sat 02/14	 Mainly clear, 40°F / 26°F	Valentine's Day; Travel day	Christmas Enchiladas	Sade – Love Deluxe

Parenting Corner

Love in Action

Valentine's week isn't just about cards and candy — it's a chance to explore what love looks like when it's a verb. How do we show care through cooking together, through small kindnesses at school, through making someone's favorite meal? This week, look for moments to ask Elsie: what does love look like when you do it, not just say it?

Dinner Conversation Starters

SUNDAY — PHILLY CHEESESTEAKS

"If you could make any sandwich in the world for your best friend, what would you put on it and why?"

Connects food to friendship and generosity. At 8, she's deeply invested in best-friend dynamics — this lets her express care through a creative, low-stakes scenario.

MONDAY — SHAKSHUKA WITH FETA

"What's the bravest thing you saw someone do today — even if it was something small?"

Eight-year-olds are building their moral compass and starting to notice courage in everyday actions. This question helps her practice recognizing bravery beyond physical feats — standing up for someone, trying something new, admitting a mistake.

TUESDAY — BABO PASTA WITH ALFREDO

"If our family had a theme song, what would it sound like? Fast or slow? Loud or quiet? What instruments?"

Swim lesson nights are rushed — this question is pure fun with no right answer. It invites creativity and reveals how she perceives the family's energy. Plus, there's music playing (Say She She) — she can riff off what she hears.

WEDNESDAY — KALE CAESAR SALAD

"What's something you're really good at that you didn't used to be good at? How did you get better?"

At 8, she's developing a growth mindset — the ability to see effort as the path to mastery. This question helps her narrate her own competence story, which builds resilience for future challenges.

THURSDAY — MUSHROOM PAPPARDELLE

"Valentine's Day is coming up — if you could show love to someone at school without using words, how would you do it?"

This ties directly to the weekly theme of 'love in action.' It pushes her to think about non-verbal expressions of care — saving a seat, sharing a snack, drawing a picture. These are the building blocks of empathy.

FRIDAY — BAKED BRONZINO WITH ROASTED KALE

"What's something you wish grown-ups understood better about being 8?"

This is a trust question. It says: I want to understand your world. Eight-year-olds often feel unheard by adults — this invites her to be the expert. Listen without correcting.

SATURDAY — CHRISTMAS ENCHILADAS

"What are three things you love about our family — not things we have, but things we do?"

Valentine's Day dinner — the perfect moment to talk about family love. Asking about actions (not possessions) reinforces that love is demonstrated, not just felt. Travel day makes this a great car conversation too.

Daily Plan

Seven days of dinner, music, and good company

Family Corner

Conversation starters, parenting nudges, and connection ideas

DAILY PLAN

Sunday, February 8

It's 17°F with wind gusts up to 44 mph — the kind of Sunday where you don't leave the house unless someone's on fire. Which makes it the perfect day for cheesesteaks, board games, and Franc Moody's disco-funk warming the kitchen like a space heater with a bassline.

☀️ Sunny, 17°F / 8°F · Sunny (89%), wind 19 mph (gusts 44 mph), 0% precip. Bitter cold.

Philly Cheesesteaks

AMERICAN

Classic Philly cheesesteaks with paper-thin ribeye from RD, seared screaming-hot on a cast-iron griddle until the edges crisp and the fat renders. Provolone melted directly over the beef, sautéed onions caramelized until sweet, all piled into garlic-butter-toasted hoagie rolls.

ribeye steak, provolone cheese, hoagie rolls, onions, peppers

Pick up steak from RD beforehand. Quick cook — sear thin slices at high heat.

CHEF'S TIPS

PREPARATION: Worcestershire Fond Glaze — During the last 30 seconds of cooking the beef, hit it with a tablespoon of Worcestershire sauce directly on the screaming-hot griddle. Let it sizzle and caramelize into the meat. This creates a savory glaze that makes the steak taste more like steak.

SAUCE: Garlic Butter Roll Toast — Melt 2 tbsp butter with 1 minced garlic clove. Split hoagie rolls, brush the insides with garlic butter, and griddle cut-side down until golden and crisp. The butter creates a moisture barrier that prevents the bread from going soggy.

TEXTURE: Crispy Shallot Rings — Thinly slice 2 shallots into rings. Toss in seasoned flour, shake off excess, and fry in 350°F oil for 2-3 minutes until deeply golden. Drain on paper towels, salt immediately. Pile on top of the assembled cheesesteak.

ACID: Quick-Pickled Hot Peppers — Slice banana peppers or cherry peppers into rings. Cover with equal parts white vinegar and water, a pinch of sugar and salt. Let sit 15 minutes. Pile onto cheesesteaks for a bright, acidic crunch.

🎵 Franc Moody – Dream in Colour

2022 · Disco-Funk / Indie-Pop · Upbeat, funky, joyful

Born in a Tottenham warehouse studio full of vintage gear and Tabasco-bottle percussion, Franc Moody's debut is pure London disco-funk energy. Ned Franc and Jon Moody spent 18 months crafting these irresistibly funky tracks — they're playing 9:30 Club on Feb 19 if you catch the bug.

🔊 Disco-funk basslines, shimmering synths, falsetto vocals, infectious hooks

Cheesesteaks are a contact sport — hot griddle, fast hands, melted cheese flying. You need music with the same energy. Franc Moody's disco-funk basslines turn the kitchen into a dance floor while you sear.

PREP

- Pick up ribeye from RD

Prep-Ahead Checklist

- ☐ Saturday: Pick up ribeye from RD for Sunday cheesesteaks
- ☐ Wednesday night: Make pizza dough for Thursday potluck heart pizzas
- ☐ Thursday morning: Shape and bake heart-shaped mini pizzas for potluck
- ☐ Thursday afternoon: Make fresh egg pasta dough, rest 30 min
- ☐ Friday afternoon: Prep kale-tomato-bean bed for bronzino
- ☐ Friday evening: Prep enchilada filling and both sauces for Saturday

Monday, February 9

Monday at the office with a demo running until 5 PM. By the time you walk in the door, you want something that requires exactly one pan and zero decisions. Shakshuka delivers — eggs, spiced tomatoes, feta, bread, done.

 Sunny, 32°F / 8°F · Sunny (90%), wind 8 mph, 0% precip. Cold but calm.

 Conduit Demonstration and Planning 4:00-5:00 PM (Reston Conf Room 5.1B)

Shakshuka with Feta

NORTH AFRICAN / ISRAELI

Eggs poached in a smoky, garlicky tomato sauce spiked with harissa and finished with cold labneh dollops and a shower of za'atar. The contrast between the searing-hot sauce and the cool yogurt is what separates this from 'eggs in tomato sauce.' Serve with thick-cut sourdough for dunking — the yolk situation demands it.

eggs, canned tomatoes, bell peppers, feta cheese, cumin, paprika, crusty bread

One-skillet, 20 minutes. Perfect after a long office day.

CHEF'S TIPS

SAUCE: Harissa Swirl — Stir 1-2 tsp of harissa paste into the tomato sauce before adding eggs. Then dot another teaspoon on top in small spoonfuls and drag a knife through for a marbled effect. The harissa blooms in the heat.

ACID: Za'atar and Lemon Finish — The moment the skillet comes off heat, sprinkle 1 tsp za'atar over the eggs and squeeze half a lemon across the whole dish. Add a few torn mint leaves.

TEMPERATURE: Cold Labneh Dollops — Drop 3-4 tablespoons of cold labneh (or thick Greek yogurt) in dollops around the hot shakshuka right before serving. Don't stir it in. The cold-hot contrast is the point.

Makaya McCraven – In These Times

2022 · Jazz / Hip-Hop · Warm, meditative, groovy

Chicago drummer and producer Makaya McCraven doesn't just play jazz — he deconstructs and reassembles it with a hip-hop producer's ear. 'In These Times' layers live ensemble recordings with lush strings and vibraphone into something warm, unhurried, and impossible to stop playing.

 Live jazz ensemble cut-and-pasted with hip-hop sensibility, lush strings, vibraphone

After a full office day, you need music that doesn't ask anything of you but gives everything back. McCraven's meditative grooves match shakshuka's one-skillet simplicity — both are layered, warm, and better than they have any right to be for something so effortless.

BEVERAGES

- Malbec wine
- pomegranate juice
- sparkling water
- Japanese lager (Asahi or Sapporo)

POTLUCK THURSDAY

- pizza dough
- marinara sauce
- mozzarella (shredded)
- pepperoni
- red bell pepper

DAILY PLAN

Tuesday, February 10

The warmest day of the week at 48°F — practically spring by this week's standards. But swim lessons mean the evening is a sprint: home, cook, eat, go. Babo Alfredo is the answer — 20 minutes, four ingredients, infinite comfort.

☁ Overcast, 48°F / 26°F · Sunny (87%), 80% cloud cover, wind 7 mph, 1% precip. Warmest day of the week.

- 📅 Alex 1:1 3:35-4:00 PM
- 📅 COBRA Core & Deployments 4:05-4:30 PM
- 📅 Swim lessons (evening)

Babo Pasta with Alfredo Sauce

ITALIAN

Silky fettuccine Alfredo made the Roman way — no cream, no shortcuts. Just good butter, a mountain of freshly grated Parmigiano-Reggiano, and the starchy pasta water doing the heavy lifting to create a glossy emulsion that clings to every strand. Finished with a snowfall of lemon zest from 12 inches above the bowl — the aromatic citrus oil brightens everything without breaking the sauce.

fettuccine, butter, Parmigiano-Reggiano, pasta water, garlic

Quick comfort food before swim lessons. Use Babo brand pasta.

CHEF'S TIPS

PREPARATION: Toasted Garlic Chip Garnish — Slice 4-5 garlic cloves paper-thin. Slowly cook in 2 tbsp olive oil over medium-low heat, swirling constantly, until light gold — about 3 minutes. Remove immediately to a paper towel. They'll darken as they cool. Reserve the garlic oil.

ACID: Lemon Zest Snowfall — Using a Microplane, zest one lemon directly over each plated bowl of Alfredo from about 12 inches above. The zest should fall like snow. Do not squeeze the lemon — you want fragrance, not juice.

TEXTURE: Cracked Black Pepper and Toasted Breadcrumbs — Toast 1/4 cup panko in butter until deep gold. Season with flaky salt. Crack pepper aggressively — you want visible flecks. Serve both tableside.

🎵 Say She She – Prism

2022 · Disco-Soul / Funk · Warm, groovy, empowering

Say She She is a Brooklyn trio channeling the shimmering three-part harmonies of 70s disco-soul through a modern indie lens. 'Prism' sounds like Chic and Rotary Connection had a baby and raised it on Afrobeat. They're at 9:30 Club on Feb 17 — two days before Franc Moody hits the same stage.

🔊 Three-part harmonies, vintage disco production, funk guitar, Afrobeat percussion

Pasta night needs warmth without drama. Say She She's vintage disco-soul provides exactly that — the three-part harmonies float over the simmering butter like steam rising from the pot. Groovy enough to keep energy up before swim lessons.

Grocery List

PRODUCE

- lacinato kale (2 bunches)
- blood oranges
- cara cara oranges
- radicchio
- Brussels sprouts
- Honeycrisp apples
- red & golden beets
- grapefruit
- cherry tomatoes
- bell peppers
- onions
- garlic
- lemons
- limes
- cilantro
- sage
- flat-leaf parsley
- arugula
- scallions
- avocado
- tomatillos
- green chiles

PROTEIN

- ribeye steak (from RD)
- whole bronzino (2, butterflied)
- eggs (2 dozen)
- shredded rotisserie chicken

DAIRY

- butter (2 lbs)
- Parmigiano-Reggiano
- Pecorino Romano
- feta cheese
- burrata
- goat cheese
- provolone
- mozzarella (fresh)
- cream cheese
- Cotija cheese
- Mexican crema

PANTRY

- fettuccine (Babo brand)
- 00 flour
- canned crushed tomatoes
- white beans (canned)
- dried porcini mushrooms
- panko breadcrumbs
- dried red chiles
- cumin
- paprika
- smoked paprika
- coriander
- hoagie rolls
- corn tortillas
- pita bread
- crusty bread
- croutons
- pistachios
- pecans
- walnuts
- dried cranberries
- Castelvetro olives
- anchovy fillets
- Dijon mustard
- whole-grain mustard
- champagne vinegar
- apple cider vinegar
- sherry vinegar
- red wine vinegar
- extra-virgin olive oil
- walnut oil
- white wine
- honey
- chickpeas (canned)

MUSHROOMS

- cremini mushrooms
- oyster mushrooms

Wednesday, February 11

Midweek reset. No meetings, working from home, 45°F outside. This is the day to take an afternoon walk, massage some kale, and let the week breathe. A big, punchy Caesar salad for dinner because not every night needs to be heavy — sometimes the salad is the main event.

☁ Overcast, 45°F / 30°F · Sunny (90%), 52% cloud cover, wind 13 mph, 18% precip.

Kale Caesar Salad with Crispy Chickpeas

AMERICAN

Lacinato kale — the sturdy, blue-green variety that doesn't wilt into nothing — massaged with olive oil and lemon until tender, then tossed in a proper anchovy-lemon Caesar dressing with shaved Parmesan, herbed croutons, and chickpeas roasted with cumin and smoked paprika until they shatter when you bite them. This isn't a side salad. This is dinner.

lacinato kale, anchovy, lemon, Parmesan, chickpeas, garlic, croutons

Hefty dinner salad. Roast chickpeas with cumin and smoked paprika for crunch and protein.

CHEF'S TIPS

PREPARATION: Warm Anchovy-Garlic Oil Drizzle — Gently warm 3 tbsp olive oil with 2 chopped anchovy fillets and 1 sliced garlic clove over low heat until the anchovies dissolve — about 3 minutes. Drizzle this warm oil over the dressed kale just before serving.

TEXTURE: Parmesan Frico Shards — Mound 2-tbsp piles of grated Parmesan on a parchment-lined baking sheet. Bake at 400°F for 5-6 minutes until golden and lacy. Cool completely — they'll shatter into crispy shards. Stand them upright in the salad.

ACID: Preserved Lemon Dice — Dice 1 tbsp preserved lemon rind very finely. Scatter over the salad. If you don't have preserved lemon, mix lemon zest with a pinch of salt and let sit 10 minutes.

🎵 Hiroshi Yoshimura – Music for Nine Post Cards

1982 · Japanese Ambient / Minimalism · Serene, crystalline, meditative

Originally commissioned for Tokyo's Hara Museum of Contemporary Art in 1982, Yoshimura's debut is nine pieces of pure stillness — sparse electric piano and warm analog synths that were designed to merge with the museum's architecture, not compete with it. The 2017 reissue introduced it to a global audience who immediately understood: this is music you live inside.

🔊 Sparse piano, warm analog synths, silence as instrument, environmental music

A clean, bright salad dinner needs clean, airy music. Yoshimura's crystalline ambient doesn't fill a room — it reshapes it. The silence between notes is as intentional as the lemon in the dressing. Both are exercises in restraint that somehow feel abundant.

PREP

- Massage kale with olive oil and lemon juice 30 min before serving

Beverage Pairings

Malbec (Red Wine)

Full-bodied, plummy Malbec from Mendoza — the ideal companion for a beef-heavy week. \$12-15 range.

Pairs with cheesesteaks, pappardelle, and enchiladas.

Sparkling Pomegranate Mocktail

Pomegranate juice, fresh lime, simple syrup, and sparkling water over ice. Festive ruby-red.

Non-alcoholic option for the family. Valentine's-worthy color.

Japanese Lager (Asahi or Sapporo)

Crisp, clean Japanese lager served ice-cold. Cuts through rich miso or umami flavors.

Light contrast to the umami-heavy bronzino and kale dinner.

Thursday, February 12

Thursday pulls double duty: Valentine's heart-shaped mini pizzas for the potluck lunch at work, then home to make fresh egg pasta from scratch for dinner. The pappardelle is the week's cooking project — hands in flour, dough resting, mushrooms browning — and it's worth every minute.

☁ Overcast, 37°F / 27°F · Sunny (92%), 87% cloud cover, wind 13 mph, 11% precip.

🍷 Valentine's Day potluck lunch (bring heart-shaped mini pizzas)

Mushroom Pappardelle with Fresh Egg Pasta

ITALIAN

Wide ribbons of fresh egg pappardelle — the kind you can only get by making it yourself, with that tender, silky chew — tossed with a mix of cremini, oyster, and rehydrated porcini mushrooms seared until deeply golden in brown butter with crispy sage. The porcini soaking liquid gets reduced to a syrup and stirred in — it's liquid umami. Finished with toasted walnuts and a splash of sherry vinegar you'll barely taste but absolutely miss if it's gone.

00 flour, eggs, cremini mushrooms, oyster mushrooms, dried porcini, butter, white wine, sage, Parmesan

Make the fresh egg pasta dough in the afternoon and rest it. Roll and cut wide pappardelle before dinner.

CHEF'S TIPS

SAUCE: Brown Butter with Crispy Sage — In a separate small pan, cook 4 tbsp butter over medium heat until it foams, goes quiet, then turns nutty brown — about 4 minutes. Drop in 8-10 sage leaves and fry 30 seconds until crisp. Pour the brown butter over plated pasta. Set crispy sage leaves on top.

PREPARATION: Porcini Soaking Liquid Reduction — Strain the porcini soaking liquid through a coffee filter to remove grit. Reduce it by half in a small pot. Add this concentrated mushroom liquor to the sauce when you deglaze with white wine. It's liquid umami.

TEXTURE: Toasted Walnut Crumble — Toast 1/3 cup walnut halves in a dry pan until fragrant. Roughly chop. Scatter over plated pasta with a grinding of black pepper.

ACID: Sherry Vinegar Finish — Just before tossing the pasta into the mushroom pan, add 1 tsp good sherry vinegar to the sauce. Toss immediately. The vinegar will mostly evaporate, leaving behind complexity.

Roasted Beet & Citrus Salad with Goat Cheese

Earthy roasted beets with grapefruit and orange segments, tangy goat cheese, and toasted walnuts on arugula.

Dressing: Sherry-walnut vinaigrette: sherry vinegar, Dijon mustard, walnut oil, extra-virgin olive oil, minced shallot, honey, salt, pepper

Earthy beets and bright citrus in sweet-savory tension. Goat cheese adds tang, walnuts bring warmth. Valentine's-worthy colors.

🎵 Mulatu Astatke – Mulatu of Ethiopia

1972 · Ethio-Jazz · Hypnotic, groovy, mysterious

Mulatu Astatke was the first African student at Berklee College of Music. He took what he learned about jazz and Latin music and fused it with Ethiopian pentatonic scales and traditional modes to invent an entirely new genre: Ethio-jazz. 'Mulatu of Ethiopia' (1972), recorded in New York, is the masterwork — vibraphone, organ, and congas moving through hypnotic minor-key grooves that sound like nothing else ever recorded.

🔊 Ethiopian pentatonic scales, vibraphone, organ, congas, walking bass, jazz arrangements

Earthy mushroom pappardelle and earthy Ethio-jazz — the pairing writes itself. The vibraphone's warm shimmer mirrors the brown butter; the walking bass echoes the deep umami of reduced porcini, and the hypnotic repetition matches the meditative rhythm of rolling fresh pasta.

PREP

- Make pizza dough Wednesday night
- Shape heart pizzas Thursday morning
- Make fresh pasta dough Thursday afternoon, rest 30 min

Appetizers

Whipped Feta Dip with Roasted Red Peppers

Creamy whipped feta blended with roasted red peppers, garlic, and a drizzle of good olive oil. Served with warm pita triangles and crudités.

feta cheese, cream cheese, roasted red peppers, garlic, olive oil, pita

Crispy Baked Mozzarella Bites

Golden panko-crust ed mozzarella bites baked until molten inside, served with warm marinara. Kid-proof and party-ready.

fresh mozzarella, panko breadcrumbs, eggs, flour, marinara sauce

Salads

COMPOSED DINNER

Winter Citrus & Radicchio Salad

Composed plate of blood orange and cara cara segments, shaved radicchio, burrata, toasted pistachios, and Castelvetro olives.

Dressing: Blood orange vinaigrette: fresh blood orange juice, champagne vinegar, Dijon mustard, extra-virgin olive oil, minced shallot, flaky salt, cracked black pepper

Bitter radicchio tamed by sweet citrus and creamy burrata. Pistachios add crunch. Italian amaro-dolce-grasso balance.

SIDE

Shaved Brussels Sprout Slaw with Apple & Pecans

Thinly shaved Brussels sprouts with Honeycrisp apple matchsticks, toasted pecans, dried cranberries, and Pecorino Romano.

Dressing: Apple cider vinaigrette: apple cider vinegar, whole-grain mustard, honey, extra-virgin olive oil, salt, pepper

Brussels sprout bitterness against sweet apple and tart cranberries. Pecans add warmth. Vinaigrette keeps it crisp and lively.

Friday, February 13

Friday is a split operation: Elsie at YAT until 6, Laura at book club. Dan picks up Elsie, comes home, and slides a prepped sheet pan of bronzino into a hot oven. Twenty-five minutes later: crispy-skinned fish over roasted kale, and the whole evening ahead for just the two of them.

☁ Overcast, 36°F / 24°F · Sunny (92%), 39% cloud cover, wind 11 mph, 22% precip.

- 📅 Laura book club (evening)
- 📅 Elsie YAT 4:30-6:00 PM

Baked Bronzino with Roasted Kale

MEDITERRANEAN

Butterflied bronzino roasted at 425°F over a bed of lacinato kale, burst cherry tomatoes, and white beans — the fish makes its own pan sauce from lemon, garlic, and good olive oil as it cooks. Scored skin with thyme tucked into the slashes, finished under the broiler for two minutes until the skin crackles. Topped with a crispy caper and lemon zest gremolata that adds brightness and crunch to every bite.

whole bronzino (butterflied), lacinato kale, cherry tomatoes, white beans, lemon, garlic, olive oil

Can prep the kale-tomato-bean bed ahead. Nestle fish on top when home from picking up Elsie. 25 min in oven.

CHEF'S TIPS

- SAUCE: Ladolemono (Greek Lemon-Olive Oil Sauce)** — Whisk 1/4 cup best olive oil with juice of 1 lemon, 1 minced garlic clove, 1 tsp dried oregano, salt, and pepper. Spoon generously over the fish the moment it comes out of the oven. The heat emulsifies the sauce.
- PREPARATION: Score and Stuff the Fish** — Score the skin of the butterflied bronzino with 3 diagonal slashes on each side. Tuck thin lemon slices and thyme sprigs into the slashes. This looks dramatic and allows heat and seasoning to penetrate evenly.
- TEXTURE: Crispy Caper and Lemon Zest Gremolata** — Pat dry 2 tbsp capers. Fry in olive oil for 1 minute until they bloom open and turn crispy. Mix with finely grated lemon zest and 1 tbsp chopped parsley. Scatter over the plated fish.
- TEMPERATURE: Room-Temperature Tomato-Bean Salad Base** — Toss the roasted cherry tomatoes and white beans with a splash of red wine vinegar while warm, then let them cool to room temperature before plating under the hot fish.

Kitchen & Pantry

Appetizers, salads, beverages, and your shopping list

🎵 Laufey – Bewitched

2023 · Jazz-Pop / Bossa Nova · Dreamy, romantic, bittersweet

Laufey (pronounced 'Lay-vay') is an Icelandic-Chinese jazz-pop prodigy who studied cello at Berklee before becoming the youngest artist ever to win the Grammy for Best Traditional Pop Vocal Album. 'Bewitched' blends golden-age jazz sensibility — think Chet Baker, Ella Fitzgerald — with bossa nova rhythms and Gen-Z lyrical honesty. It's intimate, romantic, and quietly sophisticated.

🔊 Jazz guitar, gentle strings, bossa nova rhythms, intimate vocals

Light fish, light music. Laufey's bossa nova-inflected jazz is airy enough for delicate bronzino and romantic enough for the night before Valentine's Day. The intimacy of her voice — close-miked, almost whispered — matches the intimacy of a solo dinner with your daughter.

PREP

- Prep kale-tomato-bean bed before picking up Elsie

🎵 Sade – Love Deluxe

1992 · Smooth Jazz / R&B · Sensual, sophisticated, warm

There's a reason Sade's 'Love Deluxe' (1992) is the only album anyone ever needs for Valentine's Day. 'No Ordinary Love' opens with a bass line that sounds like a heartbeat. 'Kiss of Life' is the kind of song that makes you slow-dance in the kitchen. The whole record moves with the confidence of someone who knows exactly what they're doing — smoky, elegant, and impossibly cool.

🔊 Smooth jazz, quiet storm R&B, African rhythms, silky vocals, saxophone

It's Valentine's Day. There is exactly one album. Sade's smoky sophistication turns enchiladas from a casual dinner into a candlelit event. The African rhythms underneath the quiet storm R&B mirror the Mexican warmth of the dish. No debate, no alternatives.

PREP

- Prep enchilada filling and sauces Friday night
- Assemble on arrival, bake 20 min

DAILY PLAN

Saturday, February 14

Valentine's Day, the clearest sky of the week, and a travel day. The enchilada filling and both sauces are prepped from Friday night — all that's left is assembly and 20 minutes in a hot oven. The visual alone — half red, half green, topped with pink pickled onions — is a Valentine worthy of the occasion.

☀️ Mainly clear, 40°F / 26°F · Sunny (92%), 5% cloud cover, wind 7 mph, 20% precip. Clearest day of the week.

- 📅 Valentine's Day
- 📅 Travel day

Christmas Enchiladas

MEXICAN

Enchiladas divorciadas — the dramatic 'divorced' presentation with rich red guajillo-ancho chile sauce on one side and bright tomatillo-green chile sauce on the other. Corn tortillas quick-fried for pliability and flavor, filled with shredded chicken and cheese, topped with crema, Cotija, cilantro, pink pickled red onions, and toasted pepitas. The two sauces meet in the middle of the baking dish like a delicious peace treaty.

corn tortillas, shredded chicken, red chile sauce, tomatillo green sauce, Cotija cheese, crema, cilantro
Travel day — can prep filling and sauces Friday night. Assemble and bake on arrival.

CHEF'S TIPS

- PREPARATION: Toast and Fry the Tortillas** — Before filling, pass each corn tortilla through hot oil (350°F) for 5-8 seconds per side — just enough to make them pliable and slightly golden. This prevents them from going soggy under the sauce and adds a subtle fried corn flavor.
- SAUCE: Bloom the Dried Chiles Properly** — For the red sauce: stem, seed, and dry-toast the chiles (guajillo + ancho) in a hot, dry skillet until they blister and become fragrant — about 30 seconds per side. Then soak in just-boiled water for 20 minutes. Blend with roasted garlic, oregano, and a splash of the soaking liquid.
- ACID: Quick-Pickled Red Onion Garnish** — Thinly slice 1 red onion into rings. Cover with lime juice, a pinch of salt, and a pinch of sugar. Let sit 20 minutes until bright pink. Pile on top of enchiladas after baking.
- TEXTURE: Toasted Pepita Garnish** — Toast 1/4 cup raw pepitas (pumpkin seeds) in a dry skillet over medium heat, tossing frequently, until they puff and start to pop — about 3 minutes. Season with a pinch of salt and a squeeze of lime.